Avigdor Lieberman, meant to be Israel's top diplomat, veered even further off-message: a ceasefire would be "mere preparation" for the next war, he argued, so Israel should "go all the way" and reoccupy Gaza. (Even Tzipi Livni, the centrist former foreign minister, negotiator with the Palestinians, and Netanyahu critic, suggested helping the PA topple Hamas.) None of them were sacked, though the prime minister probably would have liked to have taken action. "They're the heads of parties, so the prime minister cannot fire them," Danon said. "The consequences would be new elections. That's the only issue, because if you compare my remarks to theirs, they were very similar."

Shamed and confused

Across the border, they claimed victory. Moments after the ceasefire was announced on 26 August, a clutch of Hamas officials gathered outside Shifa, the main hospital in Gaza City, yelling defiant slogans and praising the "steadfastness" of the resistance. "We scored victory when we destroyed the myth of the army that can't be defeated, and when we closed the Zionist airspace, shelled cities, and forced the Zionists to go into hiding," said Sami Abu Zuhri, one of the group's Gaza-based spokesmen.

The next day it was Ismail Haniyeh's turn: The head of the Hamas politburo in Gaza drove through a victory rally in a white SUV, emerging from the sunroof to bust a few awkward dance moves before thousands of supporters. And on 28 August Khaled Mesha'al, the group's overall leader, seemed positively jubilant at a press conference in the Qatari capital. "Our resistance will continue until all our demands are met, and we are getting closer to victory," he said.

As victories go, this was a dubious one. More than 2,100 Palestinians had been killed during seven weeks of fighting, and even Israeli officials admitted that a majority of them were civilians. Tens of thousands of homes were destroyed, 25 per cent of the strip's population was displaced, and basic infrastructure was shattered. Aid agencies estimated that it would take decades to repair the damage, a prediction that was still accurate as this book went to press. The carnage finally ended with a warmed-over version of the ceasefire that had stopped the 2012 war—full of vague promises to ease the blockade, but little of substance. Most of them would go unfulfilled over the coming years.